

Local Services Ads: Know the Pitfalls Going In

Top Tier Roofing and Remodeling: a working guide, not a case against LSA

READ BEFORE YOU TURN IT ON

LSA is a good channel and it is worth running. This sheet is not the case for or against it, that decision is made. It is the list of traps that catch contractors who did not see them coming, so you walk in with your eyes open.

1 The badge is not instant RESEARCH

The Google Verified badge requires proof of license, proof of insurance, and a background check on the owner and on field staff, run by a third-party screener. Plan on several weeks between applying and going live, not a few days. Have your license and insurance documents ready before you start the application so paperwork is not the delay.

2 You pay per lead, and bad leads are hard to get credited RESEARCH

You are charged when a customer contacts you, even a missed call that goes to voicemail. Google now scores leads automatically and issues some credits on its own, but it no longer credits leads simply because the caller was outside your service area or wanted a job you do not do. Getting the service area and job types right at setup matters more than it used to, because there is less recourse afterward.

3 A busy week can spend faster than you expect RESEARCH

You set a weekly budget, but Google can spend above it in any single week, up to a monthly cap. In storm season, a surge in calls can burn the monthly cap early and take you dark for the rest of the month, right when demand is highest. Watch the spend during storm weeks rather than assuming it evens out on its own.

4 Ranking rewards reviews and fast answering, not just budget RESEARCH

Google's own ranking factors are your bid, your review count and rating, and your responsiveness to calls and messages. Answering quickly is already a strength here, so this one works in your favor as long as whoever answers the phone keeps doing what they are already doing.

5 More reviews buys more leads, not necessarily cheaper ones RESEARCH

A thin review count does not always show up as a higher price per lead, it shows up as winning fewer of the auctions in the first place. The fix is the same either way: a steady flow of new Google reviews is what moves this number, and it is free.

6 Leads are often shared with other contractors GENERAL

KNOWLEDGE

A homeowner can request quotes through LSA from more than one company at the same time. Being first to respond is a real advantage, not a courtesy.

7 LSA reviews sit on a separate page from your main Google reviews GENERAL KNOWLEDGE

A review collected through the LSA flow shows on your Local Services profile, not automatically on your regular Google Business Profile listing that customers find through Maps and search. Keep asking for reviews directly on your Google Business Profile as well, LSA does not replace that.

8 Service area and job type settings quietly cut you out RESEARCH

If a town, ZIP code, or job type is not checked in your LSA settings, you simply do not appear for that search, no error, no notice. Review these settings whenever the service area or the job mix changes, not just once at setup.

9 Your business name has to match, everywhere, exactly RESEARCH

The name on your license, your certificate of insurance, your Google Business Profile, and your LSA application all need to read identically. A mismatch is one of the most common reasons approval stalls. Check this before you apply, not after Google flags it.

Research = confirmed in the project's own LSA research, sourced to Google's published documentation. confirmed in the project's own research.

General knowledge = well-established LSA practice, not separately